UNIT 9

Cultural Development in South India

Learning Objectives

- To understand state and society in early medieval south India
- To know the nature of political conflict between Chalukyas and Pallavas
- To understand the cultural exchanges occurring in south India under the two antagonistic kingdoms
- To study the artistic greatness of monuments at Ajantha, Ellora and Mamallapuram
- To study the devotional movements and impressive growth of vernacular literature in early medieval south India.

Introduction

The political history of south India during the sixth century to ninth century CE was marked by conflicts between the Chalukyas of Badami (Vatapi) (also known as Western Chalukyas), and the Pallavas of Kanchi. At the same time, the period also saw great advancements in the field of culture and literature. It also broke new grounds in areas like devotional literature, art and architecture. The Bhakti movement, which impacted the entire sub-continent, originated in the Tamil country during this period.

Sources

Inscriptions on copperplates, on temple walls and pillars form a major source of historical information for this period. Inscriptions issued by Chalukyas in Kannada, Telugu, Tamil and Sanskrit languages, and Pallavas in Tamil and Sanskrit, recording land grants to Brahmins, as well as the royal and the non-royal gifts made to religious establishment are equally important sources. The Aihole inscription of Pulikesin II composed by his court poet Ravikirti in Sanskrit is among the most important of Chalukyan inscriptions. *Kavirajamarga*, a work on poetics in Kannada, *Vikramarjuna-vijayam*, also called *Pampa-bharata,* by Pampa in Kannada, which were all of a later period, and Nannaya's *Mahabharatam* in Telugu also provide useful historical data.

However, pride of place must go to Tamil literature. The Bhakti movement which originated in South India found its greatest expression in the songs composed by the Azhwars and Nayanmars. The poems of the Vaishnavite Azhwars were later compiled as the *Nalayira Divya Prabhandam*. The Saiva literature was canonized as the *Panniru Tirumurai*. The *Thevaram,* composed by Appar (Thirunavukkarasar), Sambandar (Thirugnanasambandar) and Sundarar; and *Thiruvavasagam* by Manickavasagar are prominent texts which are read as sacred literature to this day. *Periyapuranam* written by Sekizhar, in a later period, also provides much historical information. The *Mathavilasa Prahasanam* written by Mahendravarman I in Sanskrit, is an important source for the Pallava period.

Many inscriptional sources including the Allahabad Pillar inscription of Samudragupta

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